

Swimming: sport, health and water safety

Theme: Sport & society · Grammar: modal verbs of obligation

A1-A2

Words to know

Word	Meaning
lifeguard	a person who watches swimmers and keeps them safe
danger / dangerous	something that can hurt you
safe	not in danger
rule	something you must or must not do
drown	to die in water because you cannot breathe

Reading

Swimming is very good exercise. It is good for your heart. It is good for your muscles. You can swim when you are young or old.

But swimming can also be dangerous. Every year, about 320,000 people die from drowning around the world. Most accidents do not happen far out in the sea. They happen in swimming pools, rivers, and lakes — often near the edge.

Lifeguards help keep swimmers safe. But they cannot watch everyone at the same time. This is why every swimmer must be careful too.

Adapted from NHS / Sport England / World Health Organisation

Comprehension — true or false

1. Swimming is bad for your heart.
2. Most drowning accidents happen far out at sea.
3. Lifeguards can watch everyone all the time.
4. Every swimmer must be careful.

Grammar — modal verbs

Modal	Meaning	Example
must	you have to do this	"You must listen to the lifeguard."
mustn't	never do this	"You mustn't run by the pool."
should	it's a good idea	"You should stay near your group."

Exercise A — fill in the blank

Word bank: *must · mustn't · should*

1. You _____ run next to the pool.
2. You _____ listen to the lifeguard.
3. You _____ stay close to your group.
4. You _____ push other swimmers.
5. You _____ tell the teacher if you feel unwell.

Exercise B — match the modal to its meaning

must mustn't should

A. It's a good idea B. You have to C. Never do this

1. must = _____ 2. mustn't = _____ 3. should = _____

Safety rules for this afternoon — read carefully**⚠ IMPORTANT — READ EVERY RULE**

- You **must** tell the teacher immediately if you cannot swim or feel unwell.
- You **must** follow the lifeguard's instructions at all times.
- You **must not** run on the poolside.
- You **must not** push anyone into the water.
- You **should** stay in the area assigned to your group.
- You **should** tell a supervisor immediately if you see someone in difficulty.
- You **do not have to** swim if you feel uncomfortable — you may watch from the poolside.
- Snorkels, masks, and flotation devices are **not permitted** during this session.

Each student reads one rule aloud and translates it. The group confirms the translation is correct.

Vocabulary — words of the day

Core (everyone): lifeguard · danger · safe · rule · drown

Extension (B1-B2): supervision · fatality · awareness · simultaneously · compulsory

Swimming: sport, health and water safety

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B1-B2

Pre-teach vocabulary

Match each word to its meaning.

Words: simultaneously · fatality · awareness · compulsory · supervision

A. a death caused by an accident B. knowing about something C. at the same time D. watching over someone to keep them safe E. something you must do

Reading

Swimming is often described as the ideal form of exercise. Unlike running or team sports, it works every major muscle group simultaneously, puts minimal stress on joints, and can be practised at any age. Studies show that regular swimmers have lower rates of heart disease, better sleep quality, and reduced levels of anxiety and depression.

In the UK, swimming is the most popular physical activity after walking, and it has produced world-class athletes such as Adam Peaty, nine-time breaststroke world-record holder.

But swimming also carries risks. Drowning is one of the leading causes of accidental death worldwide, with around 320,000 fatalities each year according to the World Health Organisation. Most drowning incidents do not involve rough seas or strong currents — they happen in swimming pools, rivers, and lakes, often close to the shore, and often involve people who could swim.

The key factors in water safety are awareness, supervision, and knowing your limits. Lifeguards save lives — but they cannot watch everyone at once. Swimmers must take responsibility for their own safety and that of others.

Adapted from NHS / Sport England / World Health Organisation

Comprehension

- ★ Give two health benefits of swimming, and say how many people die from drowning each year (WHO figure).
- ★★ The text says most drowning incidents happen to people "who could swim." What does this suggest about the main cause of drowning?
- ★★★ "Swimmers must take responsibility for their own safety and that of others." Do you agree this responsibility should rest with the individual, or with institutions? Justify in 3-4 sentences.

Grammar — modal verbs of obligation and safety

Modal	Strength	Example
must	strong obligation (rule)	"You must shower before entering the pool."
mustn't	absolute prohibition	"You mustn't run on the pool deck."
should	recommendation	"You should tell a lifeguard if you can't swim well."
don't have to	not compulsory	"You don't have to swim if you feel unwell."
can't	not permitted	"You can't use a snorkel during this activity."

★★★ More formal alternatives: "You are not allowed to..." · "It is compulsory to..." · "It is forbidden to..."

★★ Task — Swimming pool rules

Groups of 3. You are in charge of safety at a swimming pool. Write 6 rules for swimmers: at least one positive (must/should), one prohibition (mustn't/can't), and one optional rule (don't have to).

Vocabulary: lifeguard · shallow end · deep end · lane · poolside · float · diving board · locker · capacity · non-swimmer · emergency exit

- _____
- _____
- _____
- _____
- _____
- _____

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Vocabulary — words of the day

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Sport and mental health

After the swimming session · Oral discussion + writing

EVERYONE

Debrief

Round the class — one sentence each:

"Swimming today was [more / less / as] [adjective] as I expected because..."

B1-B2

Discussion — Which sport has been best for our wellbeing?

Groups of 4. Each person defends a different sport from this week (darts, crazy golf, swimming, bowling tomorrow). The moderator calls a vote at the end.

Useful language: "I would argue that... because..." · "Unlike [sport], swimming..." · "The most beneficial aspect is..." · "However, you could say that..." · "In terms of mental health, [sport] is [better/worse] than... because..."

A1-A2

Simple version

Say one sentence: "*I think [sport] is the best because...*" + one reason.